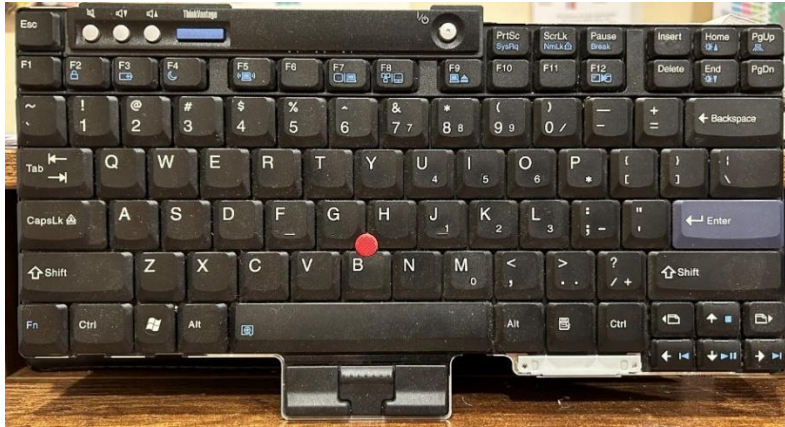
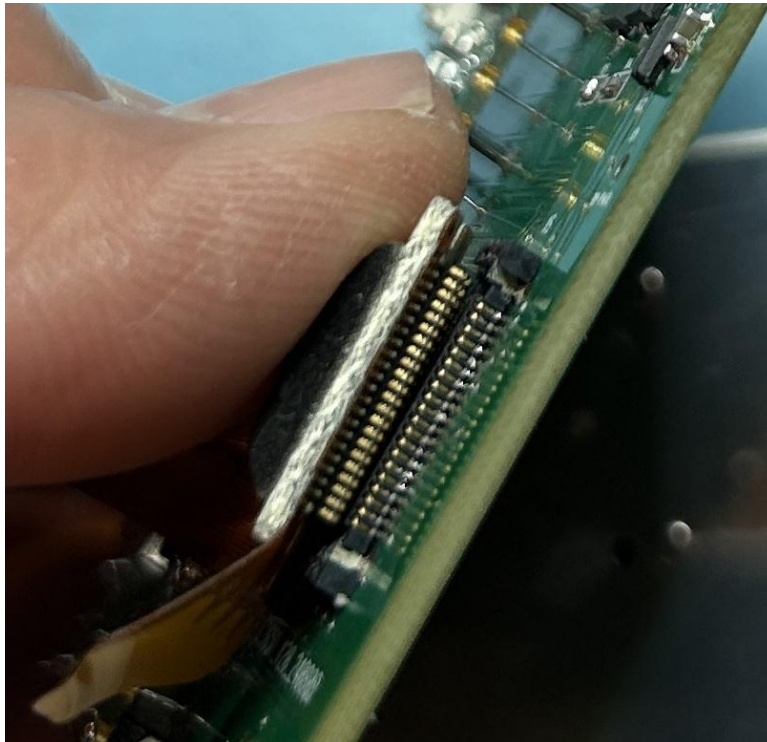


Raspberry Pi Pico Keyboard Controller for the Lenovo T61 and T420 - 7/21/2026

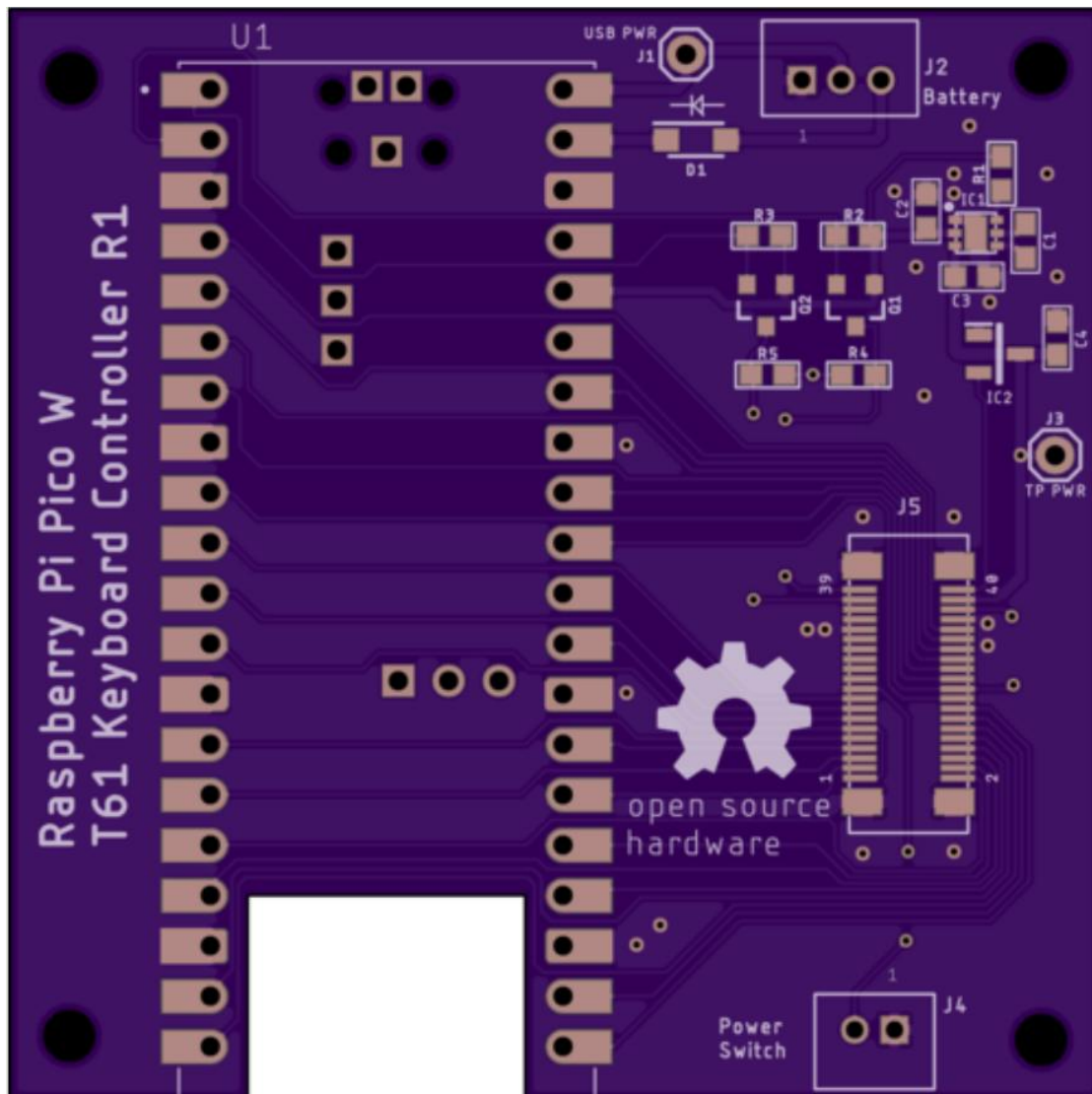
This document will describe a Raspberry Pi Pico USB controller for the Thinkpad T60 series keyboards like the T61 shown below. The T400 series keyboards are also supported using a slightly different circuit board. KMK and QMK were both able to control the keyboard. The QMK code was also able to control the trackpoint. All associated files are at my [Github repository](#) and I've added this project to step 18 of my [Instructable](#). I used a Raspberry Pi Pico W controller in the hopes that I could make a Bluetooth keyboard but QMK does not support this interface. KMK does not support BLE but claims to support Bluetooth. So far, I have not been able to make this work.



The 44 pin connector soldered to the end of the FPC cable has 4 corner pins that are not used when installed in the 40 pin board connector. The board connector part number is [AA01B-S040](#) and is available from Ali-Express. The picture below shows how to manually align the contacts so there is an extra contact on each end.

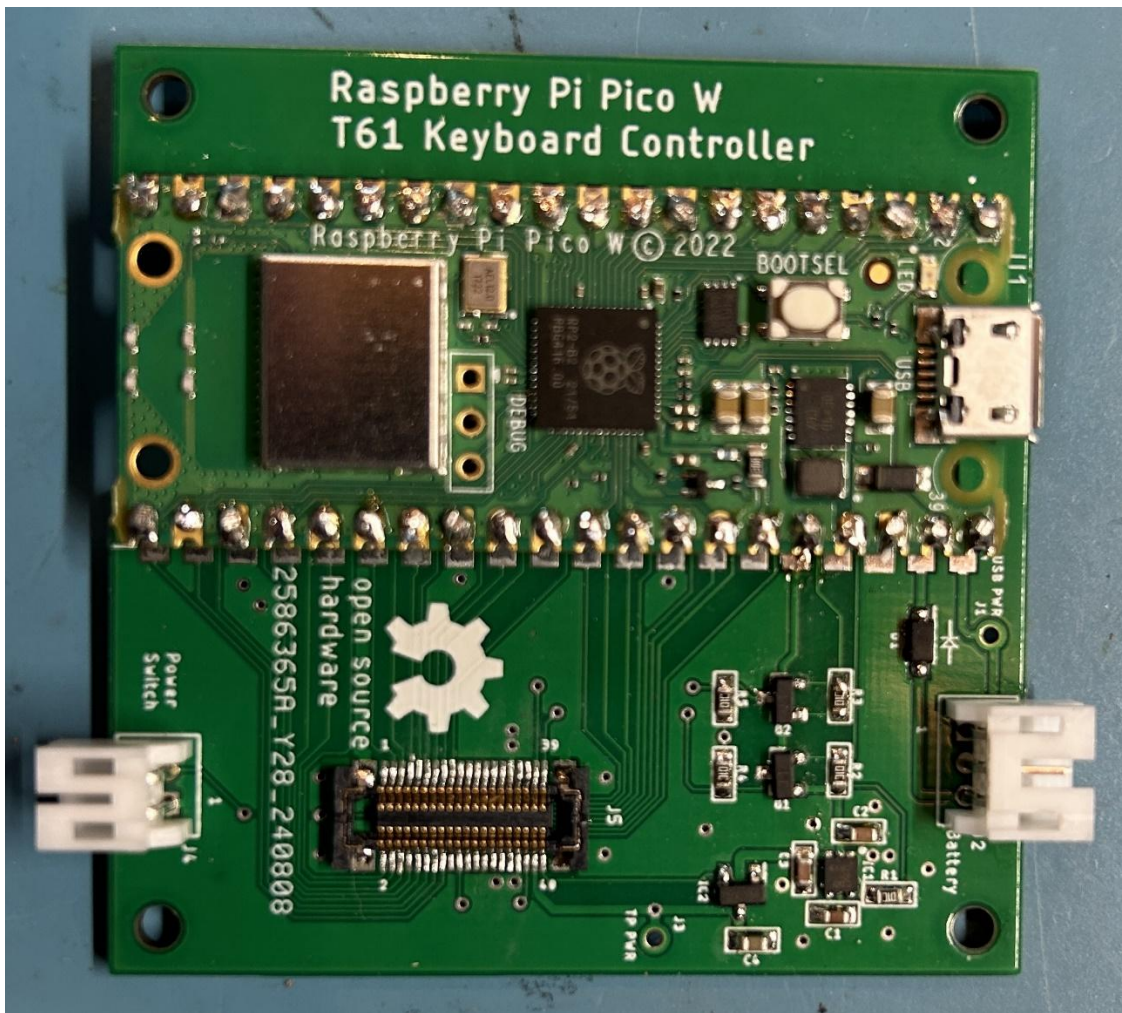


The GPIO pins of the Raspberry Pi Pico are connected to the 40 pin AA01B-S040 connector with the circuit board shown below. The other surface mount components provide level translation, reset generation, and 5 volt power for the TrackPoint.

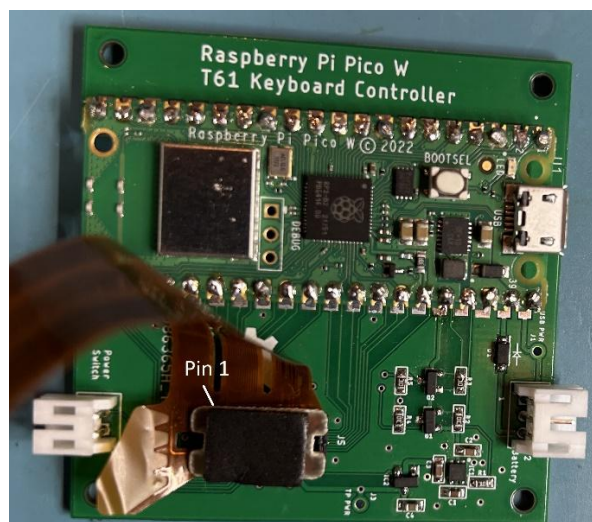


The cutout in the board gives better reception for the Bluetooth antenna on the Pico. The Pico can be mounted with header pins or soldered directly to the board for a lower profile. The Eagle file “Pico_T61_Keyboard_R1.brd” or “Pico_T420_Keyboard_R1.brd” can be sent to OSH Park or Eurocircuits. The Gerber file “Pico_T61_Keyboard_R1_2026-07-21.zip” or “Pico_T420_Keyboard_R1_2026-07-21.zip” can be sent to any fab house such as JLCPCB or PCBWay. The layout and schematic files are in the [Eagle directory](#) at my repo. Hand soldering the keyboard connector with an iron is challenging. I prefer applying solder paste to the surface mount pads using a [stencil](#). You can use a hot plate and heat gun to melt the solder but a reflow oven, such as the converted toaster oven described [here](#), makes the job much easier.

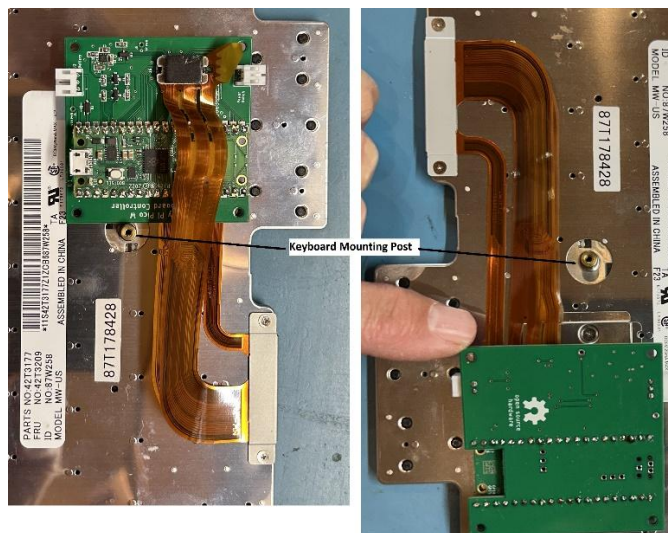
The picture below shows the assembled T61 board that was manufactured by [JLPCB](#).



There is no keying so it's possible to rotate the keyboard connector 180 degrees. See the picture below for the correct orientation of pin 1 on the FPC cable connection.



The circuit board can either be mounted facing up or down as shown below. The keyboard mounting post clears the board in both cases.



The Eagle schematic “Pico_T61_Keyboard_R1.sch” is in the Eagle Layout folder at my [repo](#) and shown on the next page. In the same folder is the Eagle schematic “Pico_T420_Keyboard_R1.sch” which changes the HOTKEY_RTN from pin 36 to pin 34. Everything else is the same as the T61. The trackpoint clock and data GPIO pins had to be swapped for the QMK library. That’s why everything has R1 in the name.

The TrackPoint circuitry in the keyboard is powered with 5 volts and draws about 6ma. The Pico GP I/O’s are not 5 volt tolerant so there are BSS138 N channel FETs labeled Q1 and Q2 that act as level translators for the TrackPoint Clock and Data signals. The TrackPoint reset signal can be created with a resistor and capacitor but to be more reliable, I’ve included a TLV810MDBZR reset generator labeled IC2. It creates a 120msec active high reset pulse at 4.38 volts. A 2 pin JST connector at location J4 can be installed if you have an off-board power latch circuit that will be controlled by the keyboard’s “Power” button.

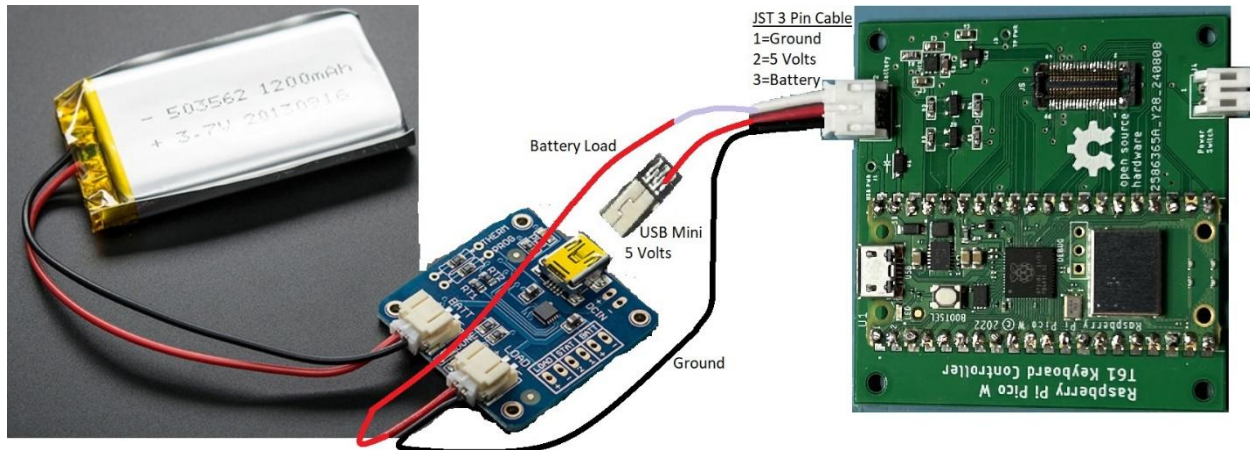
Bluetooth operation implies the board will be running from a [lithium battery](#) which ranges from 3 to 4.2 volts. When the battery needs charging, a USB cable is connected to the PICO from a power source. Bluetooth operation can continue while the battery is charging. USB 5 volts is “or tied” with the battery voltage via Schottky diodes. These diodes feed the Pico’s internal 3.3 volt buck/boost regulator. One diode is internal to the Pico and the other is labeled D1 on the board. I’ve routed the Pico’s 3.3 volts to a TPS60150 switched capacitor charge pump labeled IC1 that creates the 5 volts to power the TrackPoint and level translators.

If the keyboard will only be used for USB, solder a jumper wire between test points J1 and J3. This routes USB 5 volts directly to the TrackPoint. Do not install charge pump IC1 or its associated components, R1, C1-C3. Do not install Schottky diode D1 or the 3 pin JST connector at J2. You will still need the PS/2 level translators at Q1, Q2, R2-R5, for the TrackPoint clock and data signals.

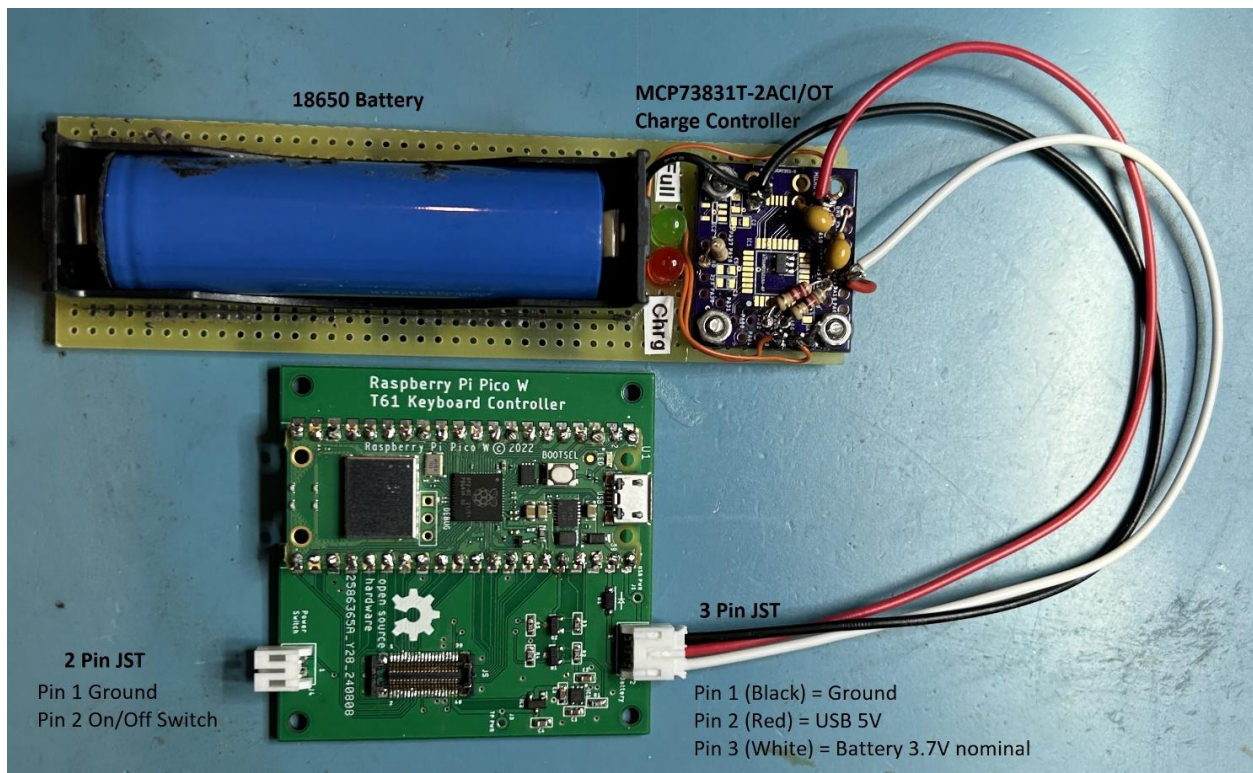


Schematic for Thinkpad T61 keyboard controller (R1)

The 3 pin JST connector labeled J2 on the board is [cabled](#) to the [battery](#) and [charging circuit](#). Pin 1 on the JST connector is ground, pin 2 is USB 5 volts, and pin 3 is the battery output. This picture shows the cable connections using Adafruit components. Their charger board needs a USB mini connector to feed in 5 volts.



Instead of buying a lithium battery and charging circuit, I put my own together using an MCP73831T-2ACI/OT controller chip and battery salvaged from a laptop (see below).



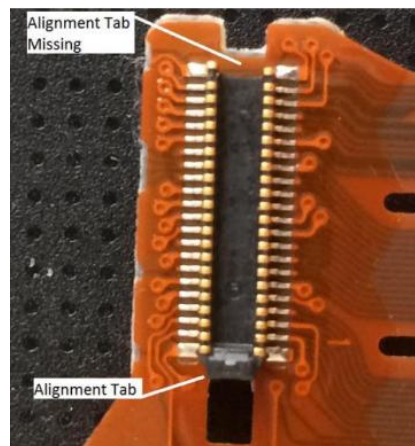
Parts list with supplier links for the Assembled Circuit Board is shown below.

Qty	Part Number	Ref	Description
1	KGM15BR71H104JM	C4	0.1uF 0603 X7R Ceramic Chip Capacitor 50V 10%
5	RC0603JR-0710KL	R1-R5	10K 0603 5% tolerance 1/10W Chip Resistor
1	KGM15AR71C105KT	C1	1 uF 0603 X7R Ceramic Chip Capacitor 16V 10%
2	KGM15BR51A225KM	C2, C3	2.2 uF 0603 X5R Ceramic Chip Capacitor 10V 10%
2	BSS138	Q1, Q2	BSS138 N-Channel MOSFET SOT23-3 50V 230ma
1	AA01B-S040	J5	40 Pin Keyboard Connector
1	S2B-PH-K-S	J4	2 Pin right angle JST Board Connector 2mm
1	S3B-PH-K-S	J2	3 Pin right angle JST Board Connector 2mm
1	MBR120VLSFT1G	D1	Schottky Diode 20V 1A
1	Raspberry Pi Pico W	U1	Raspberry Pi Pico W with or without Header pins
1	TLV810MDBZR	IC2	Reset Generator Active High 4.38V 120ms Push-Pull SOT23-3
1	TPS60150DRVR	IC1	5V 140ma switched capacitor voltage converter WSON-6 package
1	Pico T61 Keyboard R1	PWB	Printed Wiring Board manufactured using Eagle file "Pico_T61_Keyboard_R1.brd" or Gerber file "Pico_T61_Keyboard_R1_2026-07-21.zip"

The total parts cost is about \$70 if using [OSHPark](#) or about \$55 if using [JLCPCB](#) (with slow shipping). A [lithium battery](#), [charging circuit](#), [USB Mini connector](#), and [3 pin JST cable](#) will cost about \$40.

OSH Park sends you 3 boards and JLCPCB sends you 5 boards so build this project with friends to spread out the cost. You will save a few bucks if you order the Pico without header pins. You can install your own headers or solder the Pico directly to the board. I installed header pins on the grounds for a robust connection and 30 gauge wires on GPIO's so I could reroute signals for debug.

The board has surface mount pads for the keyboard connector that are extra-long to accept an alternate connector, Digikey part number [WM6787CT-ND](#). This was done just in case the AA01B-S040 is not available (I think there is only one source). I've used the WM6787CT-ND connector on previous T61 projects and it works fine. It lacks the plastic guides on each end so you must visually align the pins when mating with the keyboard connector. Even the AA01B-S040 needs help with alignment if the plastic guides on the keyboard connector have broken off (see below). The guides break off if you're way off when pushing it into the board connector (my bad).



The T61 keyboard connections to the Pico GP I/O and other devices are shown below.

Lenovo ThinkPad T61 FPC Connector	Pico GP I/O number	Notes	T61 Schematic Signal Name
1	9	Added to key matrix	HOTKEY
2	12		DRV<4>
3	20		SENSE<5>
4	19		DRV<5>
5	11		SENSE<0>
6	13		DRV<8>
7	21		SENSE<3>
8	18		DRV<6>
9	10		SENSE<2>
10	14		DRV<3>
11	9		SENSE<4>
12	15		DRV<7>
13	22		SENSE<1>
14	17		DRV<2>
15	8		SENSE<6>
16	16		DRV<10>
17	7		SENSE<7>
18	26		DRV<1>
19		PWR SW – J4 Pin 2	PWR SW
20	6		DRV<9>
21	No connect		NC
22	27		DRV<0>
23	No connect		NC
24	5		DRV<11>
25	No connect		KBDID0
26	4		DRV<14>
27	No connect		KBDID1
28	28		DRV<12>
29	No connect		KBDID2
30	3		DRV<15>
31	Pico GND		KBDID RTN
32	2		DRV<13>
33	No connect		NC
34	Pico GND		KBDID RTN
35	No connect		NC
36	6	Added to key matrix	HOTKEY RTN
37	0	Level Translated	TP_DATA
38		5 volts from TPS60150	TP_5V
39	1	Level Translated	TP_CLK
40		TLV810 Reset Generator	TP_RESET

Note1: The T420 keyboard uses pin 34 as the HOTKEY_RTN instead of 36.

Note2: The original PCB connected 37 to GPIO 1 & 39 to GPIO 0. The trackpoint wouldn't work for QMK.

The Pico inputs are the Sense<0> through <7> columns across the top which must be programmed with pullup resistors. The Pico outputs are the Drive<0> through <15> rows on the side and are either driven low or floated. Floating a pin is done by making it an input.

Matrix for the Lenovo ThinkPad T61 Keyboard

Pico GP I/O Number	Sense<0> GP 11	Sense<1> GP 22	Sense<2> GP 10	Sense<3> GP 21	Sense<4> GP 9	Sense<5> GP 20	Sense<6> GP 8	Sense<7> GP 7
Drive<0> GP 27	Back-Tick	1	Q	Tab	A	Esc	Z	
Drive<1> GP 26	F1	2	W	Caps-Lock	S		X	
Drive<2> GP 17	F2	3	E	F3	D	F4	C	
Drive<3> GP 14	5	4	R	T	F	G	V	B
Drive<4> GP 12	6	7	U	Y	J	H	M	N
Drive<5> GP 19	Equal	8	I	Right-Brace	K	F6	Comma	
Drive<6> GP 18	F8	9	O	F7	L		Period	
Drive<7> GP 15	Minus	0	P	Left-Brace	Semi-colon	Quote		Forward-Slash
Drive<8> GP 13	F9	F10		Back-Space	Back-Slash	F5	Enter	Space
Drive<9> GP 6	Insert	F12			Fn added here			Arrow-Right
Drive<10> GP 16	Delete	F11	Volume-Up	Volume-Down	Mute	Think-Vantage		Arrow-Down
Drive<11> GP 5	Page-Up	Page-Down	GUI		Menu		Page-Left	Page-Right
Drive<12> GP 28	Home	End				Arrow-Up	Pause	Arrow-Left
Drive<13> GP 2		Print-Screen	Scroll-Lock			Alt-L		Alt-R
Drive<14> GP 4				Shift-L			Shift-R	
Drive<15> GP 3	Cntrl-L						Cntrl_R	

The keyboard uses 24 Pico GP I/O's and the TrackPoint uses the remaining 2 GP I/O's. Normally the Fn signal (known as HOTKEY) is received on a dedicated GP I/O and the HOTKEY_RETURN is tied to ground. Since there are no spare GP I/O's, the HOTKEY was wired into the matrix at a blank spot as shown above. This requires the HOTKEY_RETURN to not be tied to ground. The T60 series keyboards have HOTKEY_RETURN on connector pin 36 but on the T400 series keyboards it is on pin 34. This is why there are two separate circuit boards depending on which keyboard you are using.

Software and Testing:

KMK was used to verify the Pico keyboard connections but not the TrackPoint. The [KMK Getting Started page](#) describes how to install [CircuitPython](#), the KMK folder, and main.py on the Pico. Several KMK websites and videos describe how to modify main.py for a keypad. I took their code and expanded the matrix for a T61 keyboard. The T61 main.py code at my [repo](#) is fully functional as a USB keyboard. The code switches to a second layer from the main layer when the Fn key is held down. KMK does not support PS/2 so the TrackPoint was tested with [Arduino code](#) and later with QMK. I attempted the Bluetooth keyboard settings in the KMK file but was not successful (so far).

QMK was used as a second verification of the Pico keyboard and trackpoint connections. The keyboard.json and keymap.c files were created using the procedure described in Step 17 of my [Instructable](#). The code switches to a second layer from the main layer when the Fn key is held down. The code has a third layer for the embedded number pad that is activated when the Num Lock key is selected (regardless of Fn). The trackpoint code uses the PIO in the Pico and requires the Data GPIO to be before the Clock GPIO pin. I had to swap the Clock and Data header connections to make my original board work. The R1 board at my [repo](#) fixes this problem. The QMK keyboard.json and keymap.c files are at my [repo](#) as well as my compiled Lenovo_t61_default.uf2 file. Theoretically you could build this board and flash it with my .uf2 file and it should work. Any debugging or modifications would require compiling a new .uf2 file as described in my [Instructable](#).